

another to take it. What it usually means is something that most people don't want to do: give up something today for something tomorrow.

Psychologists have done some work on this subject. What they have found is what you'd expect. People who can forgo immediate rewards in favor of longer-term goals are more successful.

In one study, for example, children were offered marshmallows. But they were given a choice. They could have one marshmallow right away. Or if they were willing to wait, they could have two later on. The children were then filmed. They fidgeted. They fussed. They struggled to resist taking the candy, because they knew that two would be more satisfying than just one.

In the study, the average child held out for a bit short of three minutes. But about 30 percent of them held out for 15 minutes and were given two marshmallows.¹

The chief researcher in these studies, Walter Mischel, had tested the friends of his own young daughters and was therefore able to keep an eye on his subjects throughout the years. As they grew up, he began to notice a link between his marshmallow tests and the girls' subsequent performances in school. Curious, he followed up with a serious inquiry into how his marshmallow tests corresponded to other areas of performance. What he found was that, generally, the children who could not wait often found themselves in difficulty later on . . . either with behavioral or academic problems. They had lower SAT scores. They had trouble paying attention. Even their friendships were weak.

On average, the kids who could wait 15 minutes had SAT scores more than 200 points higher than those who could wait only 30 seconds.

In another study, researchers offered teenagers \$1 immediately . . . or \$2 a week later. They found the results were far better indicators of academic success than IQ tests.

But the researchers didn't stop there. The kids grew up, with the psychologists looking over their shoulders. The low self-discipline children became—surprise!—fat, unsuccessful adults.

In his testing, Mischel found something interesting and a little disturbing. Children as young as 19 months old could be tested, reliably, to see if they could delay gratification. If they could, they seemed destined for success. If they couldn't, they were surely going to end up in prison or the poorhouse.